

Hairiness

(Hirsutism; Hypertrichosis)

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In men, the amount of body hair varies greatly (see also [Overview of Hair Growth](#)), but very few men are concerned enough about excess hair to see a doctor. In women, the amount of hair that is considered excessive varies depending on ethnic background and culture. Usually, excess body hair is only a cosmetic and psychological concern. However, the cause sometimes is a serious hormonal disorder, particularly in women who develop masculine characteristics (virilization).

Hairiness can be categorized as

- Hirsutism
- Hypertrichosis

Hirsutism is excessive growth of thick or dark body hair in women in locations that are more typical of male hair growth. Such locations include the face (on the upper lip, chin, or sideburn area), torso (around the nipples or on the chest, lower abdomen, or back), and limbs (on the shoulders or inner thighs).

Hirsutism



This photo shows excessive facial hair in a woman.

JOHN RADCLIFFE HOSPITAL/SCIENCE PHOTO LIBRARY.

Hypertrichosis is an increase in the amount of hair anywhere on the body in either sex. The excess hair may grow all over the body or only in specific locations. The hair may be fine, light-colored, and downlike or thick, dark, and long. This disorder may be present at birth or develop later.

Causes of Hairiness

Hair growth depends on the balance between male and female hormones. Male hormones stimulate the growth of thick, dark hair. Women normally produce small amounts of male hormones, and men produce small amounts of female hormones.

Hirsutism

Hirsutism usually results from high levels of male hormones (androgens, such as testosterone) or from increased sensitivity to normal levels of male hormones in the body. Testosterone stimulates hair growth in the pubic area and underarms. Dihydrotestosterone stimulates hair growth in the beard area and hair loss on the scalp.

Conditions that tip the hormonal balance in favor of male hormones can cause hirsutism. The balance may be tipped by excess production of male hormones. However, in hirsutism that runs in families (familial hirsutism), women's hair follicles simply appear to be more sensitive to normal levels of male hormones.

The most common cause of hirsutism is

- [Polyendocrine metabolic ovarian syndrome](#) (PMOS)

There are many less common causes of hirsutism (see table

[Some Causes and Features of Hirsutism](#)):

- Pituitary, ovarian, or adrenal gland disorders that result in overproduction of male hormones
- Tumors that produce male hormones (including certain tumors of the ovaries, adrenal glands, lungs, or digestive tract)
- Use of certain medications such as [testosterone](#), [danazol](#), or birth control pills (oral contraceptives) that have a high dose of [progesterone](#) or surreptitious use of anabolic steroids
- A familial trait, most often occurring in people of Mediterranean, Middle Eastern, or South Asian descent
- Sometimes after menopause or during pregnancy when hormone balance changes

When hirsutism is caused by increased levels of androgens, women often have [virilization](#). Virilization is the development of masculine or other characteristics in addition to excess face and body hair. For example

- The voice deepens.
- Muscle size increases.
- Hair is lost from the head.
- The clitoris (the smaller female organ that corresponds to the penis) becomes larger.
- Menstruation becomes irregular or stops completely.
- Acne may also develop.

Hypertrichosis

Hypertrichosis is caused by disorders that do *not* affect the levels of male hormones.

The most common causes of hypertrichosis are

- Certain complications of cancer ([paraneoplastic syndromes](#))

- Use of certain medications, most commonly minoxidil, phenytoin, cyclosporine, or the prostaglandin eye drops bimatoprost or latanoprost
- A serious systemic disorder, such as HIV/AIDS, brain disorders or injuries, undernutrition (including eating disorders such as anorexia nervosa and bulimia), dermatomyositis, and porphyria
- Repeated injury to and/or friction or inflammation of areas of skin (for example, an increase in hair growth that is noticed after a cast has been removed from a previously broken arm or leg)

Rarely, hypertrichosis is caused by a gene mutation. In such cases, it is usually present at birth.

Evaluation of Hairiness

Doctors must determine whether the excess hair results from a disorder or is simply a cosmetic concern.

Warning signs

In women with excess body hair, certain symptoms are cause for concern:

- Development of a deepened voice, increased muscle size, baldness, irregular or absent menstrual periods, and acne, which are signs of virilization
- Sudden appearance and rapid growth of excess hair (over weeks to months)
- A growth in the abdomen or pelvis

The sudden appearance of excess hair may suggest cancer.

When to see a doctor

If warning signs are present, people should see a doctor promptly. If excess hair appears gradually without warning signs, people should see a doctor, but the visit does not need to be scheduled as quickly.

In general, women without warning signs do not need to see a doctor if they have always had excess hair, otherwise feel well, have regular menstrual periods, have no other signs of virilization, and have family members who also have excess hair. Such women have excess body hair because it runs in their family.

What the doctor does

Doctors first ask questions about the person's symptoms and medical history. Doctors then do a physical examination. What they find during the history and physical examination often suggests a cause and the tests that may need to be done (see table [Some Causes and Features of Hirsutism](#)).

Women are asked when hair began to grow excessively and where it is located, whether they have menstrual periods, and, if so, whether periods are regular. Doctors also ask whether women have had problems conceiving a child and whether any family members also have excess hair.

Doctors ask people about all the medications and illicit drugs they are taking, particularly [anabolic steroids](#) and other drugs known to cause hair growth.

During the physical examination, doctors note the pattern of hair growth and look for other signs of virilization and for other features that suggest a cause. For example, a lump felt during the pelvic examination may suggest a tumor in an ovary.



Some Causes and Features of Hirsutism

Cause	Common Features*	Tests
Adrenal gland disorders		
Adrenal hyperplasia (enlarged adrenal glands that produce abnormally large amounts of male hormones)	Development of a deepened voice, baldness, an enlarged clitoris, increased muscle size, irregular or absent menstrual periods, and acne, which are signs of virilization When adrenal hyperplasia is present at birth, external genital organs that are not clearly male or female (ambiguous)	Blood and sometimes urine tests to measure hormone levels A <u>dexamethasone suppression test</u> (<u>dexamethasone</u>, taken by mouth, followed several hours later by a blood test to measure hormone levels)
Adrenal tumors (usually cancerous)	Signs of virilization if an adrenal tumor produces excess androgens (like testosterone), or if the person has Cushing syndrome (an adrenal tumor that makes excess cortisol [see below])	MRI or CT Blood and urine tests to measure hormone levels
<u>Cushing syndrome</u>	Excess fat throughout the torso, a pad of fat between the shoulders (buffalo hump), thin arms and legs, purple stretch marks on the abdomen, easy bruising, a large and	Urine and usually blood tests to measure the level of cortisol (which may be high in Cushing syndrome)



MSD

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